Business Insights and Recommendations

Consumer Complaint Trends and Response Intelligence Platform | Bank of America complaint records, May 2017 to 28 August 2023 | AnalystLab Africa, Week 4 (Data Analytics track)

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Scope and approach

I analysed 62,516 complaint records in the supplied Excel file. After cleaning and validation in Power Query, I built a four-page Power BI dashboard covering the executive overview, products and issues, company responses, and complaint timelines. The findings below come from that dashboard. Timely-response figures use only records with a valid Yes or No value; the 1,494 in-progress records are excluded from that calculation and reported separately.

Key figures

Measure	Result
Total complaints	62,516
Timely response (Yes / Yes + No)	96.06% (1,494 in-progress records excluded)
Average / median forwarding interval	1.22 days / 0 days
Forwarded the same day	79.4%
Forwarded after more than 25 days	623 complaints (maximum 275 days)
Untimely responses	2,403

Business insights

1. Complaint volume grew strongly over the period.

Annual complaints rose from 5,394 in 2017 (the data starts in May) to 12,953 in 2022. For 2023, the fair comparison is January to August: 9,131 complaints against 8,350 in the same months of 2022, an increase of 9.4%. The 29.5% drop shown for 2023 on the annual chart appears only because the year is incomplete.

2. Two products account for about two-thirds of all complaints.

Checking or savings accounts (24,814; 39.7%) and credit cards or prepaid cards (16,197; 25.9%) together make up roughly 66% of complaints.

3. "Managing an account" is the most reported issue by a wide margin.

It accounts for 15,109 complaints, about 24% of the total, and is almost entirely linked to checking and savings accounts.

4. Timely response performance dipped sharply in 2021.

Timely responses were between 99.3% and 99.9% from 2017 to 2020, fell to 89.0% in 2021, recovered to 95.6% in 2022, and stood at 93.2% in 2023. Performance has not returned to pre-2021 levels.

5. The CFPB forwards complaints quickly, but a small number take very long.

The median forwarding interval is 0 days and 79.4% of complaints are forwarded the same day, yet 623 complaints took more than 25 days. These cases pull the average up to 1.22 days.

6. July 2023 was the busiest month in the dataset.

It recorded 1,749 complaints, about 57% above the January to June 2023 monthly average. The data does not explain the cause, so this needs further investigation.

7. Most complaints close with an explanation only.

About 65.7% closed with explanation, 23.5% with monetary relief and 8.4% with non-monetary relief. Among records with a public response, 99.95% chose not to provide one, so that field adds little analytical value.

Recommendations

1. Target the highest-volume problems first.

Focus on account-management issues in checking and savings accounts, and on purchase disputes in credit cards, because they drive most complaints. A root-cause review and better self-service tools in these areas would reduce volume the most.

2. Monitor response timeliness and investigate the 2021 dip.

Review what caused timely responses to fall to 89.0% in 2021, and set a monthly alert when the timely response rate drops below an agreed threshold (for example, 97%) so a similar decline is caught early.

3. Review the long forwarding cases.

Examine the 623 complaints forwarded after more than 25 days to identify common products, channels or periods, and track these exceptions on the Complaint Timeline page of the dashboard.

Notes and limitations

A complaint represents an issue reported by a consumer. It does not establish misconduct or a regulatory violation. The 2023 data covers 1 January to 28 August, so August 2023 is incomplete and year-over-year changes for 2023 are not like-for-like. The forwarding interval is the CFPB forwarding time (Date received minus Date submitted), not the company response time.